

The Laocoön sculpture

This powerful group is one of the most famous of ancient classical sculptures. It may date from c. 200 BCE or later and the identity of its creator is uncertain. It shows the Trojan priest Laocoön and his two sons being attacked by snakes. One of the stories relating to Laocoön was that he was killed by serpents, along with his sons, as a punishment from the gods for having broken his vows of celibacy.

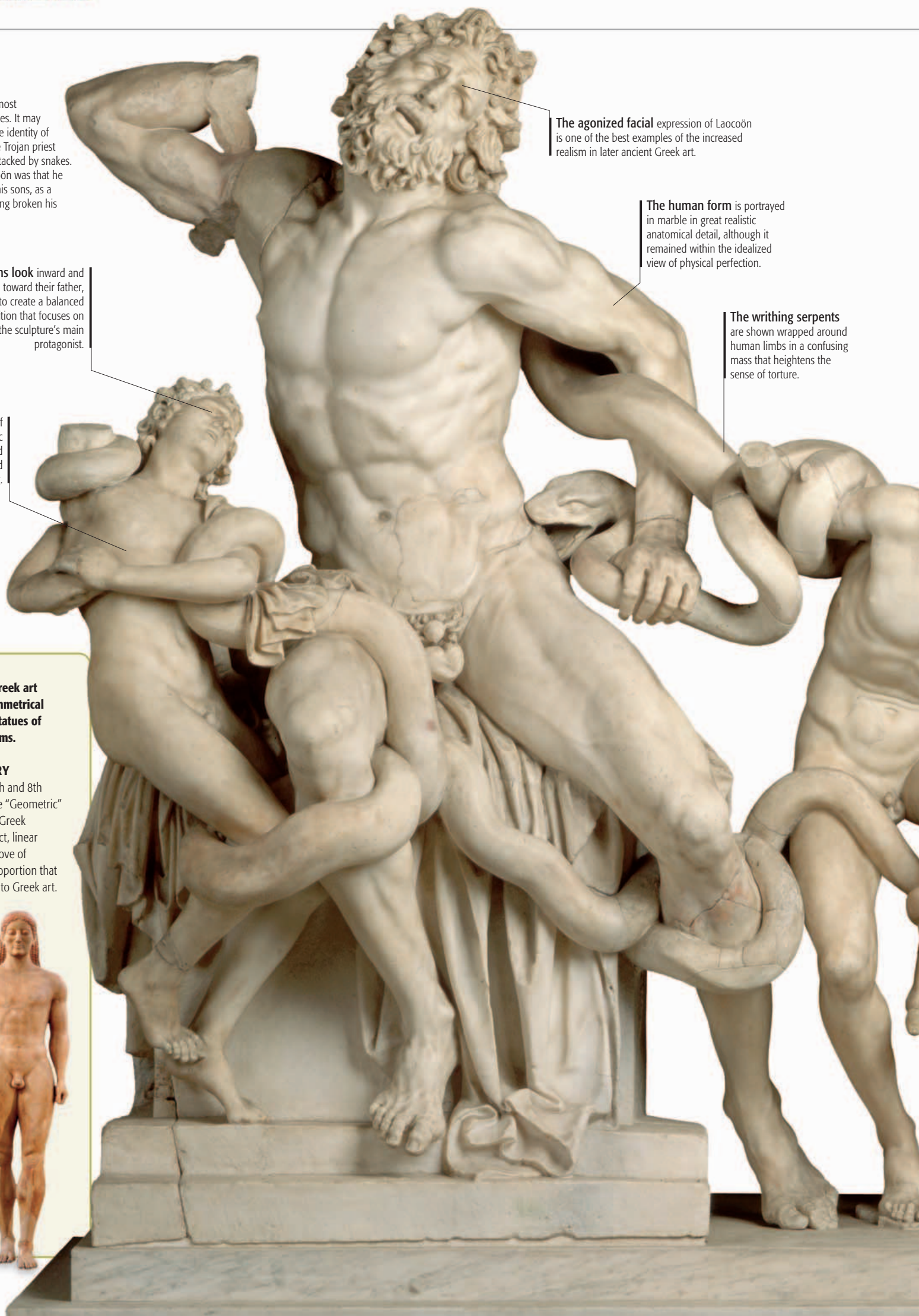
The sons look inward and upward toward their father, helping to create a balanced composition that focuses on the sculpture's main protagonist.

The twisting poses of the figures create a realistic sense of movement, and effectively express tortured writhing.

The agonized facial expression of Laocoön is one of the best examples of the increased realism in later ancient Greek art.

The human form is portrayed in marble in great realistic anatomical detail, although it remained within the idealized view of physical perfection.

The writhing serpents are shown wrapped around human limbs in a confusing mass that heightens the sense of torture.



GEOMETRIC
STYLE VASE

Examples of early Greek art include striking symmetrical pottery and stone statues of idealized human forms.

EARLY POTTERY

Between the 10th and 8th centuries BCE, the "Geometric" style dominated Greek pottery. Its abstract, linear forms reveal the love of symmetry and proportion that was so important to Greek art.

ARCHAIC SCULPTURE

The "Archaic" period (c. 750–480 BCE) is famous for its *kouros* sculptures showing an idealized human form. These forward-facing nudes show the same symmetry as early Greek pottery. Bronze casting became popular in the 500s, which made side-on poses easier to create. This led to much greater realism in the sculpture of later periods.



KOUIROS FIGURE